Velu Nachiyar - Research Dossier

Evidence notes only. Freedom-struggle stories (1757-1947), for readers around age 10. Prepared 22 October 2026. Every evidence reference and picture file title links to its opened source page.

1. Basic facts

Identity, birth, death

Name: Velu Nachiyar; also spelled Velu Nachiar, Velunachiyar or Velu Nachchiyar.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “QUEEN VELU NACHIAR”

Title: Rani (queen) of Sivaganga; also known as Veeramangai.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “She is known by Tamils as Veeramangai”

Birth: Official commemoration gives 3 January 1730; born in the Ramanathapuram (Ramnad) ruling family.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “3 January 1730”

Birthplace: Ramanathapuram/ Ramnad, now Tamil Nadu.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “of Ramnad Kingdom”

Death: Date UNSURE. The district personalities page gives 25 December 1796; the district history says the precise date is unknown and suggests around 1790. No verified place or medical cause of death was found.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “25 December 1796”

Competing death-year statement from the same district administration.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “about 1790”

Family, education and work

Father: Raja Chellamuthu Vijayaragunatha Sethupathy; mother: Sakandhimuthal (spellings vary).

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “Rani Sakandhimuthal”

Only daughter of the Ramnad ruling family.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “only daughter of this royal family”

Husband: Muthu Vaduganatha Periya Udaiya Thevar, ruler of Sivaganga; marriage at age 16, approximately 1746.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “At the age of 16”

Daughter: Vellachi Nachiyar (also Vellacci or Vellachinachiar).

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “Vellachi Nachiyar”

Education/training: Valari, stick-fighting, horse riding, archery; reported knowledge of French, English and Urdu.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “proficiency in English, French and Urdu”

Work: Sivaganga political leader and queen; returned to government around 1780, with ministers and military commanders.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “permitted to govern the Sivaganga Country”

Groups and organisations

Sivaganga ruling house and its ministers and troops.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “Chinna Marudu, the younger was appointed her minister”

Coalition with Hyder Ali and Gopala Nayakar during years away from Sivaganga.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “formed an alliance with Gopala Nayaker and Hyder Ali”

Women fighters, called Udaiyaal in the school-textbook account. Their precise membership is not documented here.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “unit of women soldiers named after Udaiyaal”

Sivaganga force with commanders Vellai/Periya Marudu and Chinna Marudu.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “the elder Vellai Marudu as the Commander-in-chief”

Nine important events, in date order

1730 - Born to the Ramnad ruling family.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Born in 1730”

About 1746 - Married the Sivaganga ruler at age 16.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “married to Muthu Vadugar”

June 1772 - Company and Nawab forces attacked Sivaganga; her husband was killed in the Kalaiyar Kovil fighting on 25 June, according to district history.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “on the 25th June 1772”

1772 - Left with daughter Vellachi after the attack; the district record names Tandavaraya Pillai.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “fled to Virupakshi in Dindigul”

1770s - Built support while in refuge around Virupachi, with Gopala Nayakar and Hyder Ali.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “at Virupachi near Dindigul for eight years”

1770s - Thandavarayanar wrote to Hyder Ali on her behalf, asking for infantry and cavalry. The document itself was not examined.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “asking for 5000 infantry and 5000 cavalry”

About 1780 - Returned to Sivaganga and resumed rule; district records mention an agreement involving tribute to the Nawab.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “subject to payment of Kist to the Nawab”

1780 - Granted governing powers to the Marudu brothers.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “granted powers to Marudhu Brothers”

About 1790 - Later accounts say her daughter Vellachi succeeded; this should be checked against the district chronology.

Open source [S10] | Exact quote: “She was succeeded by her daughter in 1790”

2. Story angles (at least 10)

Each is a research lead, not a finished story. Questions below are proposed hooks, not historical quotations.

1. The Bent Throwing Weapon

How did a young princess learn to use a valari?

The Tamil Nadu school textbook includes valari among the skills taught to her.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “martial arts like valari”

2. Marriage to a Neighbouring Ruler

How did someone from Ramnad become part of the Sivaganga court?

The district account identifies her husband as ruler of Sivaganga.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “His wife Rani Velu Nachiar”

3. An Offer to the Dutch

Why did Sivaganga seek trade with the Dutch when the English also wanted influence?

The Sivaganga district history records facilities granted to Dutch traders after the English declined.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “commercial facilities to the Dutch”

4. An Army from Two Directions

What happens when one force approaches from the east and another from the west?

The official local history identifies commanders Joseph Smith and Benjour in 1772.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “Joseph Smith from the east”

5. Trenches in the Forest

How did Sivaganga prepare the roads and woods around Kalaiyar Kovil?

The district account describes defenses made before the attack.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “dug trenches and established posts”

6. A Queen and a Daughter Leave Home

Who travelled with Velu Nachiyar after the battle?

The district history names daughter Vellachi and minister Tandavaraya Pillai.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “with Tandavaraya Pillai”

7. The Refuge at Virupachi

What kind of political help could a family seek after losing control of its kingdom?

A Tamil Nadu government biography names Gopala Nayakkar as a protector.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “under the protection of Palayakaarar Kopaala Naayakkar”

8. A Letter Asking for Soldiers

What did Thandavarayanar ask Hyder Ali to send?

The school textbook reports a request for soldiers of two kinds. The original letter has not been verified.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “5000 infantry and 5000 cavalry”

9. A Conversation in Urdu

Why does the school textbook say Velu Nachiyar spoke to Hyder Ali in Urdu?

The textbook describes the language used to explain the conflict. No transcript was located.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “explained in detail in Urdu”

10. The Commandant in Dindigul

Who did Hyder Ali instruct to help?

The textbook identifies the commandant of Dindigul Fort.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “his Commandant Syed”

11. Finding the Ammunition

How might the people planning a return learn where weapons were stored?

The textbook says agents collected intelligence about ammunition sites.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “employed agents for gathering intelligence”

12. The Shepherd Girl Udaiyaal

What do later accounts say about a girl who refused to answer soldiers?

LATER TRADITION - exact dialogue and eyewitness record not verified.

LATER TRADITION: a newspaper columnist says she was questioned about the queen.

Open source [S8] | Exact quote: “Udaiyal, a girl grazing cattle”

13. Kuyili at the Storehouse

Why do folk songs remember a woman called Kuyili?

ORAL TRADITION / DISPUTED - not an established eyewitness account.

LATER ORAL HISTORY: the Tamil Nadu textbook signals uncertainty about the arsenal action.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Kuyili is said to have walked”

The Hindu reports a shortage of written documentation.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “no written history exists about her life”

14. Return With a Payment Condition

Did regaining Sivaganga also mean agreeing to pay the Nawab?

The district history says the return was allowed with a tax or tribute condition.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “payment of Kist to the Nawab”

15. Two Brothers, Two Jobs

What happened when the queen made one brother a minister and the other an army commander?

The district describes two different appointments.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “appointed her minister”

16. Who Ruled Next?

What happened to her daughter when the queen’s rule ended?

A later newspaper summary names Vellachi as successor. The year needs cautious treatment.

Open source [S10] | Exact quote: “succeeded by her daughter in 1790”

17. What a Stamp Can Remember

Why did the government print her image on a postage stamp centuries later?

A 2014 Government of India feature records a commemorative stamp.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “31st December, 2008”

18. The Memorial for Two Women

How did a memorial bring Kuyili’s oral histories back into public discussion?

The Hindu reports that a memorial was opened in 2014.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “inaugurated by then Chief Minister Jayalalithaa in July 2014”

Flagship candidate

Angle 14 - Return With a Payment Condition. This gives a concrete political question: what did it mean to recover a kingdom if a Nawab still demanded a payment? The 1780 return, agreement and Marudu appointments are described in an official district history. A second angle about the alliance letter can accompany it. The Kuyili event is not recommended as the flagship until the oral-history evidence is presented with clear limits.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “An agreement was reached”

3. People and places connected

People, forces and organisations

Chellamuthu Sethupathy - Velu Nachiyar’s father; ruler in the Ramnad family.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “King Sellamuthu Sethupathy”

Sakandhimuthal - mother; name varies in spelling among accounts.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “Rani Sakandhimuthal”

Muthu Vaduganatha Thevar - husband, killed during 1772 fighting.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “fell dead”

Vellachi Nachiyar - daughter who left Sivaganga with Velu Nachiyar.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “Vellachi Nachiar entered Sivaganga”

Tandavaraya / Thandavarayanar Pillai - minister and reported author of the military-help letter.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Thandavarayanar wrote a letter”

Hyder Ali - leader from Mysore whose support was sought.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “Hyder Ali”

Gopala Nayakar - ruler/protector associated with Virupachi.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “Kopaala Naayakkar at Virupachi”

Syed - Dindigul commandant named in the school text.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Commandant Syed”

Periya / Vellai Marudu - elder brother and army commander.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “elder Vellai Marudu”

Chinna Marudu - younger brother and minister.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “Chinna Marudu”

Kuyili - figure in oral accounts of women fighters and an arsenal fire.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “based on oral histories and folk songs”

Udaiyaal - shepherd girl recalled in later narratives of the queen’s escape.

Open source [S8] | Exact quote: “a girl grazing cattle”

East India Company - military opponent in the Sivaganga fighting.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Company troops”

Nawab of Arcot - ruler whose troops acted with Company forces; tribute appears in the return agreement.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “Nawab”

Joseph Smith and Benjour / Bon Jour - British commanders in the 1772 attack, named in district records.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “Smith and Benjour”

Places and connected events

Ramanathapuram / Ramnad - Velu Nachiyar’s natal kingdom.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Ramanathapuram”

Sivaganga - the kingdom recovered around 1780.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “regained kingdom”

Kalayarkoil / Kalaiyar Kovil - area of the battle in which her husband was killed.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Kalaiyar Kovil Palace”

Virupachi / Virupakshi - refuge after the 1772 defeat.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “Virupakshi in Dindigul”

Dindigul Fort - location of the commandant mentioned by the textbook.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “Dindigul fort”

Dutch trade - relationship in the district’s account of Sivaganga’s foreign contacts.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “the Dutch”

Sivaganga memorial - later remembrance of Velu Nachiyar and Kuyili.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “memorial statue for Velu Nachiyar”

4. Disputes, legends and doubts

A. Death date and year - UNSURE

Version 1: the district biographies give 25 December 1796.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “25 December 1796”

Version 2: the district history says the exact date is unknown and suggests about 1790.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “exact date of her death is not known”

Research handling: Do not present an exact death date as unquestioned. The two official pages disagree. Death place and cause also remain UNSURE from these records.

B. Was she the first Indian ruler to fight the British?

Some government accounts describe her as the first queen to fight the British.

Open source [S2] | Exact quote: “first queen to fight”

The India Today fact check rejects the broader statement that she was the first Indian ruler.

Open source [S7] | Exact quote: “several Indian rulers before 1780”

Research handling: The words ruler and queen are not interchangeable. The broad first-ruler claim is unsupported; even the narrower first-queen label needs a defined comparison and further historical verification.

C. Victory in 1780: battle or negotiated restoration?

A PIB feature describes military success against Company forces.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “won the battle”

The Sivaganga history describes permission to return and an agreement requiring payment.

Open source [S1] | Exact quote: “An agreement was reached”

Research handling: Both may be part of a longer process, but the reviewed texts do not document the exact sequence. Show both; do not replace the agreement with a simple battle-only ending.

D. Kuyili and the burning of ammunition - ORAL TRADITION

The government textbook itself uses uncertain wording.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “is said to have walked”

The Hindu reports both oral sources and disagreement about the existence of Kuyili.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “some argue such a person never existed”

Research handling: Present the act as a claim preserved in later songs and retellings. The article names R. Lenin (Santhimavo) and R. Kaleeswaran as collectors and interpreters of local oral material; no eighteenth-century

eyewitness record was verified.

E. What did Udaiyaal refuse to reveal?

A school textbook links the information to Kuyili.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “information on Kuyili”

A later newspaper column links the information to the escaping queen.

Open source [S8] | Exact quote: “the queen’s whereabouts”

Research handling: This is a concrete difference between versions. Attribute both to later accounts; exact speech and location cannot be treated as fact.

F. How long did Velu Nachiyar rule?

The PIB calls the restored reign a decade.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “for a decade”

The News Minute says more than ten years before her 1796 death.

Open source [S5] | Exact quote: “more than 10 years”

Research handling: Keep the 1780 return distinct from the later succession. The endpoint is not securely resolved by these summaries.

G. The legend of a complete picture-perfect battle plan

A modern book review acknowledges creative additions made because records are limited.

Open source [S9] | Exact quote: “room to take creative liberties”

A researched newspaper report ties Kuyili narratives to oral accounts.

Open source [S6] | Exact quote: “folk songs”

Research handling: Do not turn details from a novel, stage work or later oral version into unlabelled facts. No verified contemporaneous transcript of her conversations was located.

H. Specific numbers of fighters and letter survival - UNSURE

Tamil Nadu textbook reports a request for infantry and cavalry.

Open source [S3] | Exact quote: “5000 cavalry”

The PIB feature confirms allied military help, without those numbers.

Open source [S4] | Exact quote: “military assistance of her allies”

Research handling: The request of 5,000 infantry and 5,000 cavalry is a textbook report, not proof that those numbers arrived. Original letter location and verification remain UNSURE.

5. Pictures

No lifetime portrait was established by this search. These are licenced modern photos of connected places and a later drawing, not images made during her life. Do not label an artwork as a verified facial likeness.

1. Drawing of Velu Nachiyar with the Marudu brothers, made later; NOT an 18th-century portrait.

Picture date: 29 March 1990 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (also GFDL 1.2+)

Open source [P1] | Exact quote: “Date 29 March 1990”

2. Sivagangai Aranmanai building; present-day view, not proof of the building’s appearance in the 1700s.

Picture date: 19 January 2013 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 3.0 Unported

Open source [P2] | Exact quote: “Own work”

3. Kalayarkoil site, associated with the 1772 fighting; modern photograph.

Picture date: 22 February 2018 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International

Open source [P3] | Exact quote: “Own work”

4. Dindigul Rock Fort, near the refuge and military alliance locations; modern photograph.

Picture date: 9 September 2014 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International

Open source [P4] | Exact quote: “Own work”

5. Cannons at Dindigul Fort; modern photograph, not identified as guns used in her campaign.

Picture date: 1 July 2018 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International

Open source [P5] | Exact quote: “Own work”

6. Statue of the elder Marudu brother at Kalaiyar Kovil; later memorial sculpture.

Picture date: 14 May 2016 | Licence on file page: Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International

Open source [P6] | Exact quote: “Own work”

Reuse checklist: keep creator credit, Commons file-page link and applicable licence; indicate edits and follow ShareAlike where required. Excluded: uncertain portraits, unchecked images of the stamp, and files flagged for copyright problems.

6. Sources used

These are the opened source pages and licence records used above. Source IDs in all sections link directly to the same pages.

1. History of Sivaganga District [S1]

Sivaganga District Administration, Government of Tamil Nadu

https://sivaganga.nic.in/about-district/history/

2. Eminent Personalities: Queen Velu Nachiar [S2]

Sivaganga District Administration, Government of Tamil Nadu

https://sivaganga.nic.in/tourism/eminent-personalities/

3. Social Science, Standard Ten, Volume II, Unit 6, pages 3-4 [S3]

Government of Tamil Nadu, State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERT), hosted by BYJU'S

https://cdn1.byjus.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/01/Samacheer-Kalvi-Class-10-Social-Science-Volume-2_EMHistory.pdf

4. Velu Nachiyar - India's Joan of Arc [S4]

Press Information Bureau, Government of India, 14 August 2014

https://www.pib.gov.in/newsite/PrintRelease.aspx?lang=2&reg=48&relid=108691

5. Remembering Queen Velu Nachiyar of Sivagangai [S5]

The News Minute, 3 January 2017

https://www.thenewsminute.com/article/remembering-queen-velu-nachiyar-sivagangai-first-queen-fight-british-55163

6. Kuyili: the warrior in queen Velu Nachiyar's army [S6]

Pon Vasanth B.A., The Hindu, accessed via Inkl

https://www.inkl.com/news/kuyili-the-warrior-in-queen-velu-nachiyar-s-army

7. Fact check: Queen Velu Nachiyar wasn't the first Indian ruler to fight the British [S7]

India Today, 27 December 2021

https://www.indiatoday.in/amp/fact-check/story/fact-check-queen-velu-nachiyar-from-tamil-nadu-wasnt-first-indian-ruler-to-go-to-war-against-british-1892831-2021-12-27

8. The unknown heroines of India [S8]

Nanditha Krishna, The New Indian Express, 16 October 2021

https://www.newindianexpress.com/opinion/columns/2021/Oct/16/the-unknown-heroines-of-india-2371996.html

9. Stuff of legends: Warrior Queen of Sivaganga [S9]

The New Indian Express, 30 September 2023

https://www.newindianexpress.com/amp/story/lifestyle/books/2023/Sep/30/stuff-of-legendswarrior-queen-of-sivaganga-2619086.html

10. Explained: Women heroes of India's freedom struggle [S10]

The Indian Express, 15 August 2022

https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/explained-women-heroes-of-indias-freedom-struggle-mentioned-by-pm-in-his-i-day-speech-8092077/lite/

11. Rani Velu Nachiyar and Marudhu brothers (later drawing) [P1]

Wikimedia Commons, uploader Shakthi Thevar

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Rani_Velu_Nachiyar_and_Marudhu_brothers.jpg

12. Sivagangai Aranmanai [P2]

Wikimedia Commons, photo by Nileshantony92

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Sivagangai_Aranmanai.jpg

13. Kalayarkoil (1) [P3]

Wikimedia Commons, photo by Ssriram mt

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Kalayarkoil_(1).jpg

14. Dindigul Fort [P4]

Wikimedia Commons, photo by Drajay1976

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Dindigul_Fort.jpg

15. Dindigul fort Cannons [P5]

Wikimedia Commons, photo by Kadal27

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Dindigul_fort_Cannons.jpg

16. Statue of Periya Marudhu at Kalaiyar Kovil [P6]

Wikimedia Commons, photo by Jagadeeswarann99

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:%E0%AE%AA%E0%AF%86%E0%AE%B0%E0%AE%BF%E0%AE%AF_%E0%AE%AE%E0%AE%B0%E0%AF%81%E0%AE%A4%E0%AF%81%E0%AE%B5%E0%AE%BF%E0%AE%A9%E0%AF%8D_%E0%AE%9A%E0%AE%BF%E0%AE%B2%E0%AF%88.jpg